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AN APPEAL A contractors' delegation meets with CM Siddaramaiah

KARNATAKA

THE POLITICAL CONTRACT

By Ajay Sukumaran

When the Congress government took over in Karnataka in May, it had to demonstrate its intent on one of the key issues that had propelled it to power: the allegations of 40 per cent corruption against the previous BJP government led by Basavaraj Bommai. Accordingly, one of its first moves was to freeze payments of outstanding bills for works approved during the BJP regime. But that ended up hurting the very people who had levelled the allegations: the contractors. So a month later, CM Siddaramaiah's regime softened its stand, allowing ministers to clear payments for ongoing projects after verifying them. But alongside, it also ordered probes into projects cleared in the past. The move, contractors fear, will delay the bills further, leading to stoppage of work.

In Bengaluru alone, bills worth at least Rs 4,000 crore have been held up for 26 months, claims D. Kempanna, president, Karnataka State Contractors' Association, the man who had voiced the 40 per cent theme most vigorously in 2022. Last month, Siddaramaiah entrusted a probe into his charges to retired judge H.N. Nagamohan Das. Besides, deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar, who holds the charge for Bengaluru city, set up four separate committees to check work packages awarded by the civic body Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike (BBMP) over four years.

A backlash followed the probe orders. A section of contractors approached the governor with a complaint that the Congress regime was charging commissions to release funds. The allegation, however, was quickly withdrawn with the complainants making a U-turn at a press conference. But the BJP latched on to it as proof of corruption by the new government. Siddaramaiah countered this by saying the Congress's election manifesto had promised a thorough probe into allegations against the previous regime.

CONTRACTORS FEAR THE PROBE ORDERS AGAINST THE WORKS CLEARED BY THE BJP REGIME WILL FURTHER DELAY PAYMENTS

However, contractors aren't entirely convinced with the approach. "We have to give the new government some time," says Kempanna. But launching an enquiry into the past four years, he thinks, is futile. "After four years, how can you assess the works? The guarantee period (for civil works) is normally one or two years," he points out, adding that the probe should ideally look at works executed within that period.

According to Kempanna, bills worth at least Rs 25,000 crore are pending in various departments across Karnataka. Recently, public works minister Satish Jarkiholi told the Legislative Council that the previous government had approved works entailing expenditure three times the grants available. "If grants of Rs 1,000 crore were available, works worth Rs 3,000 crore were approved. That is the primary reason for the imbalance."

Meanwhile, a Congress spokesperson says the four committees scrutinising the BBMP will likely look at whether tender processes were followed and the Transparency Act adhered to. "Third-party engineers certify the work...this process too has to be probed," he explains. At the moment, it's not clear how many work orders these four special teams will cumulatively enquire into. But it's likely to be a big exercise, says a senior officer.

In a recent meeting with the CM, the contractors appealed to him to clear at least 50 per cent of a bill value and ensure funds are released monthly. Earlier this week, Shivakumar partly acceded to this, saying a decision on releasing the remaining 50 per cent for completed BBMP projects will be taken after the enquiry. That should be some silver lining. At least for now. ■